METHODOLOGY

HOW THE UNIVERSITIES WERE RANKED

With 615 general, 71 medical, 188 technical and 26 law universities to choose from, the India Today Group's annual ranking of Best Universities has a special place in the country's academic calendar. It not only makes critical career decisions easier for aspirants due to its rich information and data but also provides a broad overview of the state of university education to other stakeholders—recruiters, parents, alumni, policymakers and people at large.

INDIA TODAY's knowledge partner Marketing and Development Research Associates (MDRA), a reputed research agency, followed a rigorous methodology while conducting this survey between January 2023 and July 2023. During objective ranking, the MDRA has carefully attuned 120-plus attributes to provide a comprehensive and balanced comparison of universities. These performance indicators were clubbed into five broad parameters—'Reputation & Governance', 'Academic & Research Excellence', 'Infrastructure & Living Experience', 'Personality and Leadership Development' and 'Career Progression and Placement'. The ranking was done based on current-year data provided by the universities.

A list of 750-plus qualifying universities fulfilling the criteria was prepared. Postgraduate courses under four streams—general, medical, technical and law—were considered for evaluation. Only universities offering full-time, in-classroom courses and having churned out a minimum of three graduating batches by the end of 2022 qualified for ranking.

Experts with rich experience in their respective fields were consulted to frame the parameters and sub-parameters for the respective categories of universities. Indicators were meticulously determined, and their relative weights were finalised.

A comprehensive objective questionnaire was sent to qualifying universities and also uploaded on the MDRA and INDIA TODAY websites. As many as 166 universities provided their data along with supporting documents within the stipulated deadline.

A list of 750-plus qualifying universities was prepared, and PG courses in four streams—general, medical, technical and law—evaluated

After receiving the objective data from universities, detailed scrutiny of the supporting documents was done. Data was verified through every possible means. An objective score was given to each university under the five indicators. While computing these objective scores, it was ensured that aggregate data alone is not used and hence data was normalised.

A perceptual survey was carried out among 309 well-informed respondents (40 chancellors/vice-chancellors, 58 directors/deans/registrars, 203 senior faculty professors and head of departments) across more than 20 cities divided into four zones. These were:

- **North: Delhi-NCR, Lucknow, Jaipur, Chandigarh**
- **West: Mumbai, Pune, Ahmedabad and Indore**
- **South: Chennai, Bengaluru, Hyderabad and Coimbatore**
- **East: Kolkata, Bhubaneswar, Guwahati and Patna**

National and zonal rankings were taken from these respondents in their fields of experience and were given 75 per cent and 25 per cent weightage, respectively. The universities were also rated on a 10-point rating scale on each of the five key parameters. The total scores from the objective and perception survey were added in the ratio of 50:50 to get the total combined score.

The MDRA core team led by Abhishek Agrawal (Executive Director) included Abnish Jha (Project Director), Vaibhav Gupta (Assistant Research Manager), Aditya Srivastava (Research Executive), Poornima Shukla (Assistant Research Executive) and Manveer Singh (Senior Executive-EDP). ■